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Customer satisfaction



In his column in the January issue of *Digit*, Edward Henning promised that we would start covering the issue of customer service, and invited readers to write in to us at servicewatch@thinkdigit.com, with any serious and properly documented examples of bad service they had received. We have received some examples from readers, although at the time of writing most of these are still under investigation. Of course, consumer rights are protected by law, and therefore, in this article, we start by looking at the relevant legislation as well as an example problem from one of our readers.

If you have a genuine problem with a vendor, often, one of the quickest ways of getting them to take action is to make it clear that you understand the law that protects you, and you are fully prepared to make use of it.

Several years ago in the UK, I learnt that when confronted by a shop or other vendor that refused to, say, exchange a printer that didn't work properly, to say something like this: "Are you not familiar with the law, under the Sale of Goods (Implied Terms) Act, 1972?"

"I am, and so is my lawyer. Your refusal to exchange my printer contravenes that law. Are we going to do this the expensive way?" That usually does the trick nicely. So, what is the equivalent here in India? In order to find out, I went along to the Department of Consumer Affairs, and met its Director, Mr. G. N. Sreekumaran. He told me that the state of customer care in India is not up to the standards that I might have seen back in the UK, and that many companies either do not give prompt and proper response, or they do not even have customer care departments. Of course he is referring to the whole range of compa-